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Many a Paradise Found

Once you take the wheel, India can seem endless. Here are 10 journeys worth steering for

I have spent the best part of my life driving. My work makes me drive and my holidays are spent driving, too. So, while it is a bit of a challenge to pick 10 of the best drives, these have made the list for the beauty, splendour, history, excitement and challenges they afford.



Manali-Leh-Srinagar

This journey, along with the various offshoots in Ladakh—east to Hanle/Umlingla or north to Nubra—has to be on the bucket list of all those who love to drive. High altitude passes present some challenges, but this is picture postcard territory wherever you look. The Zojila (now on the new alignment), for instance, presents a contrasting beauty—the evergreen Kashmir Valley on the one hand, and the high-altitude desert of Ladakh on the other.

Shimla-Reckong Peo-Kaza-Manali circuit

There are many good driving roads in Himachal Pradesh, but it is the Lahaul and Spiti Valley circuit that gives you a perfect mix of difficult terrain, attractions and scenic spots. Whether it is the oldest mummy at Gue, the drive along the Sutlej, the stark landscape around Kaza or the slight diversion to the Baspa valley and Chitkul on the old Tibet trade route, you're sure to want to return.



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Bikaner-Jaisalmer

Rajasthan is steeped in history with every small town and area having its own story to tell. For driving enthusiasts, they are all connected by a great network of roads. Start from the Shekhawati region, visit the palaces at Bikaner and stop by at the numerous solar farms around Pokhran, and dash to Jaisalmer. Beyond are the dunes at Sam and the war memorial at Longewala.



The Mughal Road

There is no doubt that Kashmir is one of the most scenic regions in India and the world, but with all the heavy traffic, getting out of Srinagar by road through the Banihal pass is quite painful. The Mughal Road, on the other hand, leads you on a path of history, away from the crowds and through some stupendous sights—the man-made 'Peer ki Gali' or the beautiful meadows in the apple town of Shopian. The best part is that despite the construction of a metalled road for light vehicular traffic, the Mughal Road is still not part of the popular tourist circuits.

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